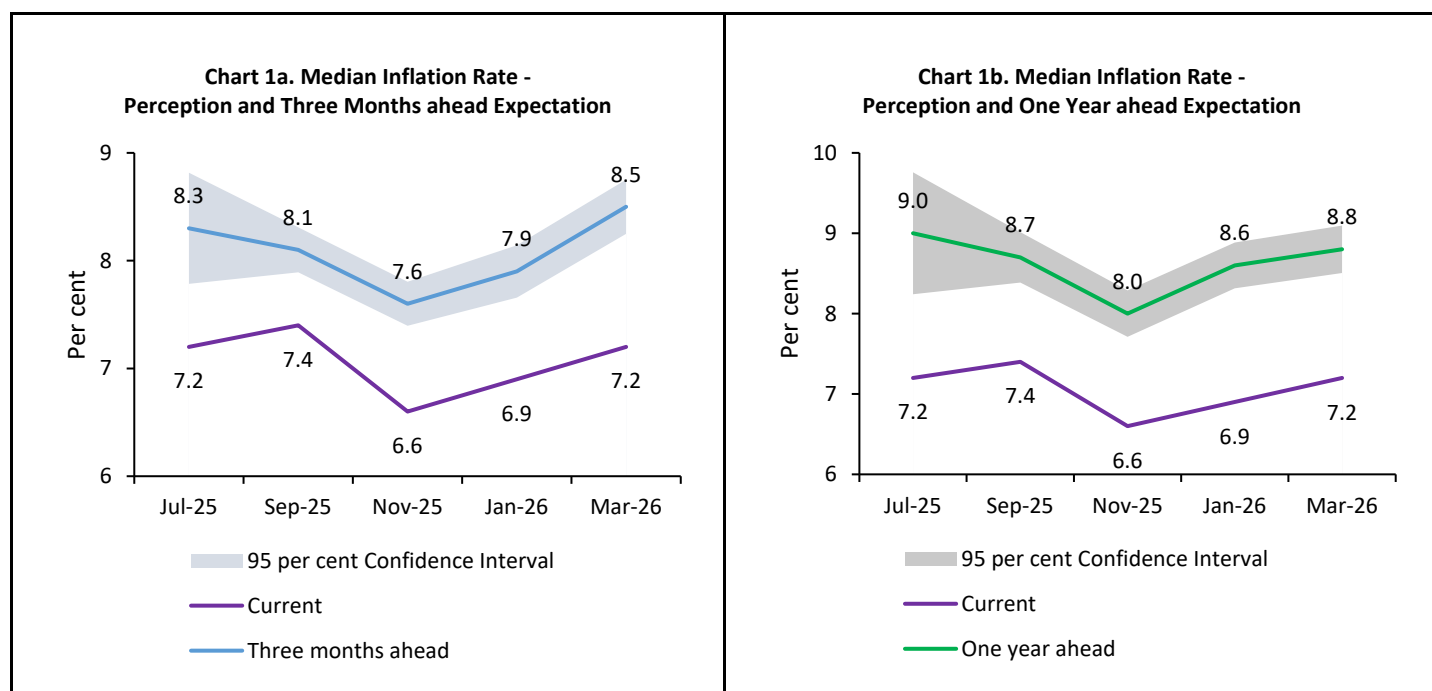


Households' Inflation Expectations Survey

Today, the Reserve Bank released the results of March 2026 round of its bi-monthly Inflation Expectations Survey of Households (IESH)^{1 2}. The survey was conducted during February 25 to March 10, 2026, in 19 major cities, with 6,075 responses.

Highlights:

- The current median inflation perception of households inched up by 30 basis points (bps) to 7.2 per cent as compared to the previous round. Their inflation expectations for the three months and one year ahead rose by 60 bps and 20 bps to 8.5 per cent and 8.8 per cent, respectively [Charts 1a and 1b; Table 3].
- For both the short-term and one-year ahead periods, the shares of respondents anticipating a rise in general prices and inflation increased for the second consecutive round [Tables 1(a) and 1(b)].
- Households expect price and inflationary pressures across most of the product groups including food product, non-food product and cost of services for both the time horizons [Tables 1(a) and 1(b)].



Note: [Please see the excel file for time series data](#)³

¹ The survey is conducted at bi-monthly intervals by the Reserve Bank; it provides directional information on near-term inflationary pressures as expected by respondents and may reflect their own consumption patterns. Hence, survey results reflect respondents' views, which are not necessarily shared by the Reserve Bank.

² All estimates of inflation expectations are given in terms of median, unless stated otherwise.

³ Results of the previous survey round were released on the Bank's website on [February 06, 2026](#). Unit-level data for previous rounds of the survey are available on the Bank's 'Database on Indian Economy' (DBIE) portal (weblink: <https://data.rbi.org.in/DBIE/#/dbie/home>) under the head 'Unit-level Data'.

Table 1(a): Product-wise Expectations of Prices for Three Months ahead

(Percentage of Respondents)

Survey period ended	Mar-25		Sep-25		Nov-25		Jan-26		Mar-26	
General	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Prices will increase	80.7	0.87	77.8	0.90	74.6	0.90	78.6	0.91	81.6	0.90
Price increase more than current rate	54.7	1.15	51.5	1.20	50.7	1.14	54.6	1.20	57.2	1.21
Price increase similar to current rate	20.8	0.86	23.1	0.89	20.2	0.87	20.6	0.87	20.9	0.85
Price increase less than current rate	5.2	0.47	3.1	0.36	3.7	0.38	3.3	0.37	3.6	0.40
No changes in prices	17.3	0.84	18.5	0.85	21.5	0.84	18.9	0.88	16.8	0.89
Decline in prices	2.0	0.27	3.7	0.43	3.9	0.41	2.5	0.35	1.5	0.24
Food Product										
Prices will increase	83.1	0.77	79.0	0.90	74.9	0.84	80.0	0.81	83.8	0.75
Price increase more than current rate	57.8	1.09	51.5	1.22	50.5	1.04	55.7	1.11	59.4	1.16
Price increase similar to current rate	18.3	0.79	22.2	1.00	18.2	0.77	18.9	0.81	18.4	0.81
Price increase less than current rate	7.0	0.54	5.3	0.45	6.2	0.49	5.4	0.46	6.0	0.52
No changes in prices	12.2	0.69	14.2	0.80	16.1	0.72	14.5	0.71	12.4	0.68
Decline in prices	4.7	0.40	6.8	0.53	8.9	0.58	5.5	0.46	3.8	0.37
Non- Food Product										
Prices will increase	75.6	0.89	73.4	0.91	67.8	0.95	72.2	0.93	77.6	0.90
Price increase more than current rate	53.3	1.07	49.4	1.19	44.3	1.08	48.8	1.16	54.0	1.15
Price increase similar to current rate	15.3	0.74	18.7	0.89	17.6	0.76	18.3	0.82	18.1	0.77
Price increase less than current rate	7.0	0.54	5.3	0.45	5.9	0.46	5.1	0.43	5.5	0.45
No changes in prices	20.2	0.82	20.1	0.80	24.7	0.87	22.7	0.87	19.0	0.86
Decline in prices	4.2	0.39	6.5	0.54	7.5	0.54	5.2	0.46	3.4	0.34
Household Durables										
Prices will increase	66.7	0.98	67.8	0.97	53.2	1.02	61.3	1.05	65.4	1.00
Price increase more than current rate	45.2	1.11	49.5	1.16	36.1	1.03	42.4	1.10	44.7	1.11
Price increase similar to current rate	15.8	0.74	14.1	0.69	13.4	0.70	15.1	0.74	15.9	0.69
Price increase less than current rate	5.8	0.51	4.2	0.39	3.8	0.38	3.9	0.36	4.9	0.44
No changes in prices	24.6	0.90	21.5	0.83	29.4	0.91	28.2	0.99	25.6	0.91
Decline in prices	8.6	0.52	10.7	0.62	17.4	0.75	10.4	0.59	9.0	0.56
Cost of Housing										
Prices will increase	78.0	0.88	77.1	0.88	77.4	0.86	78.5	0.86	78.4	0.90
Price increase more than current rate	56.5	1.09	54.9	1.15	54.8	1.12	57.8	1.10	57.8	1.14
Price increase similar to current rate	16.0	0.73	18.9	0.87	17.9	0.78	17.5	0.76	17.0	0.73
Price increase less than current rate	5.4	0.48	3.4	0.34	4.7	0.40	3.2	0.34	3.6	0.37
No changes in prices	19.1	0.84	18.7	0.81	18.5	0.81	17.9	0.81	19.1	0.88
Decline in prices	2.9	0.34	4.2	0.41	4.1	0.39	3.5	0.36	2.5	0.30
Cost of Services										
Prices will increase	69.3	0.98	66.1	1.00	63.8	0.97	68.4	0.96	69.8	1.01
Price increase more than current rate	49.0	1.10	46.2	1.17	43.3	1.11	47.3	1.14	48.7	1.14
Price increase similar to current rate	14.9	0.71	15.7	0.72	16.1	0.73	17.5	0.79	17.2	0.72
Price increase less than current rate	5.3	0.46	4.2	0.40	4.4	0.42	3.6	0.38	3.9	0.37
No changes in prices	27.8	0.95	30.0	0.98	32.5	0.95	28.3	0.96	27.9	0.98
Decline in prices	3.0	0.34	3.8	0.43	3.7	0.39	3.2	0.37	2.3	0.28

Note:

1. The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for qualitative responses.

2. Constituent items may not add up to the corresponding total, due to rounding off.

Table 1(b): Product-wise Expectations of Prices for One Year ahead

(Percentage of Respondents)

Survey period ended	Mar-25		Sep-25		Nov-25		Jan-26		Mar-26	
General	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Prices will increase	89.7	0.67	86.8	0.79	83.6	0.75	88.8	0.69	90.0	0.66
Price increase more than current rate	65.4	1.12	61.8	1.22	60.0	1.17	63.6	1.13	67.5	1.19
Price increase similar to current rate	19.7	0.88	21.7	0.94	20.6	0.88	22.9	0.93	19.6	0.88
Price increase less than current rate	4.6	0.44	3.3	0.36	3.1	0.34	2.3	0.30	2.8	0.35
No changes in prices	8.4	0.62	10.0	0.70	13.0	0.65	8.5	0.60	8.3	0.61
Decline in prices	1.9	0.27	3.2	0.41	3.4	0.41	2.6	0.34	1.7	0.27
Food Product										
Prices will increase	87.9	0.66	83.3	0.95	81.8	0.80	85.5	0.75	87.4	0.68
Price increase more than current rate	60.8	1.09	56.5	1.34	54.0	1.14	58.9	1.17	61.1	1.19
Price increase similar to current rate	21.1	0.83	22.8	1.03	22.9	0.86	22.2	0.90	21.5	0.88
Price increase less than current rate	6.1	0.49	4.0	0.41	4.9	0.44	4.5	0.42	4.8	0.45
No changes in prices	8.9	0.58	11.5	0.80	12.8	0.66	10.1	0.63	9.3	0.60
Decline in prices	3.2	0.33	5.2	0.49	5.4	0.47	4.4	0.43	3.2	0.36
Non- Food Product										
Prices will increase	82.6	0.78	79.7	0.96	78.1	0.82	80.5	0.83	83.7	0.79
Price increase more than current rate	56.7	1.11	53.6	1.27	52.7	1.11	56.5	1.17	58.6	1.18
Price increase similar to current rate	20.0	0.83	21.6	0.96	20.1	0.80	19.9	0.83	21.2	0.85
Price increase less than current rate	6.0	0.50	4.4	0.42	5.2	0.45	4.2	0.40	3.9	0.40
No changes in prices	13.9	0.71	15.4	0.84	16.6	0.72	15.4	0.75	13.4	0.73
Decline in prices	3.5	0.35	4.9	0.46	5.3	0.48	4.1	0.41	2.9	0.33
Household Durables										
Prices will increase	75.4	0.90	78.1	0.90	68.0	0.95	72.9	0.91	75.3	0.92
Price increase more than current rate	51.9	1.12	58.0	1.17	46.1	1.12	51.4	1.14	52.6	1.19
Price increase similar to current rate	17.9	0.78	16.5	0.81	17.4	0.77	17.8	0.80	18.6	0.79
Price increase less than current rate	5.6	0.46	3.7	0.37	4.5	0.44	3.7	0.37	4.1	0.42
No changes in prices	17.9	0.78	14.2	0.72	21.1	0.80	19.3	0.84	18.7	0.80
Decline in prices	6.6	0.48	7.7	0.57	11.0	0.65	7.8	0.53	6.0	0.45
Cost of Housing										
Prices will increase	88.3	0.67	87.5	0.70	87.9	0.67	88.0	0.65	89.4	0.60
Price increase more than current rate	66.5	1.03	63.8	1.14	64.9	1.08	66.9	1.06	67.0	1.08
Price increase similar to current rate	17.6	0.80	20.3	0.93	19.2	0.86	18.4	0.83	18.5	0.80
Price increase less than current rate	4.2	0.39	3.4	0.35	3.8	0.37	2.8	0.31	3.9	0.41
No changes in prices	9.3	0.60	9.1	0.58	8.6	0.56	8.8	0.56	8.9	0.56
Decline in prices	2.3	0.30	3.4	0.39	3.5	0.40	3.2	0.37	1.7	0.25
Cost of Services										
Prices will increase	82.4	0.79	81.2	0.83	79.0	0.85	81.9	0.80	82.6	0.78
Price increase more than current rate	59.4	1.07	58.4	1.15	55.1	1.16	57.2	1.16	57.2	1.15
Price increase similar to current rate	17.6	0.79	18.5	0.83	19.2	0.83	20.5	0.85	20.8	0.83
Price increase less than current rate	5.4	0.45	4.4	0.41	4.7	0.45	4.1	0.39	4.6	0.43
No changes in prices	15.0	0.74	15.4	0.77	17.6	0.77	15.2	0.75	15.4	0.75
Decline in prices	2.6	0.31	3.4	0.42	3.4	0.41	2.9	0.36	2.1	0.27
Note:										
1. The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for qualitative responses.										
2. Constituent items may not add up to the corresponding total, due to rounding off.										

Table 2: Inflation Expectations of Various Groups: Mar-26

	Current Perception				Three Months ahead Expectation				One Year ahead Expectation			
	Mean		Median		Mean		Median		Mean		Median	
	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Overall	8.2	0.09	7.2	0.13	9.3	0.09	8.5	0.13	9.1	0.11	8.8	0.15
Gender-wise												
Male	8.3	0.13	7.4	0.17	9.4	0.13	8.7	0.18	9.3	0.15	9.0	0.25
Female	8.1	0.12	7.0	0.22	9.3	0.13	8.5	0.18	9.1	0.16	8.8	0.22
Category-wise												
Financial Sector Employees	7.3	0.39	6.2	0.31	8.0	0.35	7.4	0.26	7.9	0.51	7.7	0.48
Other Employees	8.4	0.19	7.6	0.25	9.4	0.19	8.8	0.26	9.4	0.21	9.2	0.38
Self Employed	8.5	0.20	7.6	0.37	9.8	0.21	9.3	0.49	9.4	0.23	9.4	0.48
Homemaker	8.1	0.14	7.0	0.27	9.3	0.15	8.6	0.21	9.0	0.19	8.9	0.31
Retired Persons	9.0	0.33	8.6	0.64	10.2	0.35	10.1	0.43	9.4	0.40	9.7	0.60
Daily Workers	8.5	0.26	7.3	0.32	9.3	0.28	8.3	0.34	8.5	0.36	8.0	0.36
Other category	7.4	0.17	6.3	0.24	8.5	0.19	7.7	0.21	8.6	0.22	8.2	0.22
Age Group-wise												
Up to 25 years	7.4	0.16	6.4	0.23	8.4	0.18	7.7	0.18	8.7	0.20	8.2	0.24
25 to 30 years	8.0	0.18	7.2	0.21	9.0	0.20	8.3	0.23	9.0	0.23	8.9	0.40
30 to 35 years	8.2	0.18	7.1	0.27	9.4	0.20	8.5	0.37	9.4	0.23	8.9	0.41
35 to 40 years	8.1	0.19	7.2	0.31	9.4	0.20	8.9	0.31	9.1	0.24	9.1	0.45
40 to 45 years	8.5	0.20	7.7	0.34	9.9	0.22	9.5	0.45	9.4	0.25	9.5	0.50
45 to 50 years	8.2	0.24	7.0	0.34	9.3	0.23	8.2	0.35	9.0	0.27	8.4	0.32
50 to 55 years	8.6	0.24	8.1	0.44	9.9	0.27	9.3	0.56	9.5	0.31	9.2	0.59
55 to 60 years	8.3	0.29	6.8	0.49	9.3	0.29	8.2	0.39	8.4	0.38	8.1	0.44
60 years and above	9.0	0.23	8.7	0.51	10.1	0.25	10.0	0.35	9.3	0.31	9.8	0.49
City-wise												
Ahmedabad	5.9	0.23	5.5	0.12	6.6	0.33	6.3	0.24	6.3	0.38	6.3	0.35
Bengaluru	5.4	0.16	5.1	0.10	7.0	0.19	6.3	0.28	7.4	0.23	7.0	0.31
Bhopal	7.4	0.48	6.1	0.59	9.1	0.55	8.4	1.00	8.6	0.67	7.5	1.29
Bhubaneswar	7.9	0.44	7.5	0.94	9.9	0.52	9.4	0.84	10.2	0.60	9.6	1.13
Chennai	7.5	0.32	6.7	0.44	8.6	0.37	7.9	0.42	9.4	0.42	9.5	0.65
Delhi	9.4	0.24	9.4	0.58	10.3	0.26	10.2	0.21	9.6	0.30	10.2	0.32
Guwahati	7.8	0.53	6.8	0.78	8.5	0.54	7.5	0.74	8.7	0.55	8.5	0.88
Hyderabad	7.1	0.28	6.0	0.32	8.6	0.27	7.7	0.39	8.5	0.31	8.2	0.44
Jaipur	7.1	0.34	6.7	0.36	8.1	0.36	7.7	0.39	8.0	0.40	8.0	0.31
Jammu	9.6	0.91	9.8	1.16	8.0	0.89	6.8	1.45	8.5	0.84	7.7	1.63
Kolkata	10.3	0.29	10.2	0.24	11.3	0.27	11.1	0.56	10.8	0.33	11.2	0.67
Lucknow	8.2	0.45	7.7	0.61	9.1	0.56	8.6	0.69	8.8	0.53	8.6	0.72
Mumbai	9.7	0.28	9.0	0.40	10.9	0.27	10.5	0.14	10.6	0.28	10.7	0.20
Nagpur	7.5	0.44	6.9	0.56	8.6	0.51	8.1	0.67	7.8	0.94	7.9	1.25
Patna	6.9	0.42	6.2	0.54	7.7	0.46	6.9	0.57	7.1	0.56	6.5	0.69
Thiruvananthapuram	6.7	0.66	5.6	0.28	8.3	0.68	7.1	0.60	9.3	0.75	8.4	0.92
Chandigarh	8.4	0.61	8.0	0.71	9.4	0.81	9.0	0.96	9.1	0.81	8.7	0.92
Ranchi	7.7	0.43	7.2	0.40	8.3	0.36	7.8	0.35	8.1	0.65	8.1	0.60
Raipur	8.4	0.68	8.2	1.04	10.4	0.69	10.4	0.53	9.6	0.49	10.4	0.64

Note: The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for quantitative responses.

Table 3: Household Inflation Expectations – Current Perception, Three Months and One Year Ahead Expectations												
	Current Perception				Three Months ahead Expectation				One Year ahead Expectation			
	Mean		Median		Mean		Median		Mean		Median	
	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE	Estimate	SE
Mar-25	8.5	0.08	7.8	0.11	9.5	0.08	8.9	0.13	9.4	0.11	9.7	0.23
May-25	8.4	0.08	7.7	0.12	9.5	0.09	8.9	0.12	9.4	0.11	9.5	0.25
Jul-25	8.1	0.12	7.2	0.26	8.9	0.13	8.3	0.26	8.7	0.17	9.0	0.39
Sep-25	8.4	0.08	7.4	0.13	9.0	0.08	8.1	0.11	8.8	0.11	8.7	0.16
Nov-25	7.7	0.08	6.6	0.14	8.4	0.08	7.6	0.10	8.1	0.10	8.0	0.15
Jan-26	7.8	0.08	6.9	0.16	8.9	0.09	7.9	0.12	8.9	0.11	8.6	0.15
Mar-26	8.2	0.09	7.2	0.13	9.3	0.09	8.5	0.13	9.1	0.11	8.8	0.15
Note: The table provides estimates and standard errors (SE) for quantitative responses.												

Table 4: Households Expecting General Price Movements in Coherence with Movements in Price Expectations of Various Product Groups: Three Months Ahead and One Year Ahead					
(Percentage of Respondents)					
Survey period ended	Food	Non-Food	Household durables	Housing	Cost of services
Three Months Ahead					
Mar-25	64.4	67.6	60.1	65.0	68.8
May-25	63.5	64.8	60.4	63.6	67.4
Jul-25	65.9	70.5	48.7	50.9	62.7
Sep-25	59.6	63.8	65.3	64.3	71.8
Nov-25	62.4	62.6	55.1	62.1	65.4
Jan-26	65.9	66.6	60.0	64.8	68.6
Mar-26	65.5	66.5	59.0	64.6	66.4
One Year Ahead					
Mar-25	74.3	72.7	67.0	75.4	76.9
May-25	74.4	70.5	68.6	72.7	75.4
Jul-25	81.6	78.1	69.5	61.9	61.8
Sep-25	75.5	67.8	71.4	69.7	73.0
Nov-25	83.4	70.3	61.7	71.0	71.1
Jan-26	71.7	71.0	64.5	73.0	72.8
Mar-26	73.6	73.8	68.0	74.7	74.2

Table 5(a): Cross-tabulation of Number of Respondents by Current Inflation Perception and Three Months Ahead Inflation Expectations: Mar-26

Three Months Ahead Inflation Rate (per cent)																				
Current Inflation Rate (per cent)		<1	1-<2	2-<3	3-<4	4-<5	5-<6	6-<7	7-<8	8-<9	9-<10	10-<11	11-<12	12-<13	13-<14	14-<15	15-<16	>=16	No idea	Total
	<1	6	4	2	0	0	2	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	16
	1-<2	3	30	39	10	4	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	87
	2-<3	2	12	138	107	63	17	2	8	11	6	26	1	1	0	0	0	0	0	394
	3-<4	1	3	10	122	102	79	20	1	0	1	3	1	1	1	0	9	44	0	398
	4-<5	0	0	7	9	150	121	50	7	5	0	4	3	13	4	2	11	1	0	387
	5-<6	0	3	17	23	13	519	235	230	85	7	94	1	1	1	0	7	30	0	1266
	6-<7	0	0	0	3	6	11	152	107	91	20	23	0	2	0	0	0	0	1	416
	7-<8	0	0	3	2	2	5	6	219	99	47	66	1	4	0	3	1	1	0	459
	8-<9	0	0	0	0	2	1	1	7	153	67	144	15	16	4	1	3	7	0	421
	9-<10	0	0	0	0	1	1	0	2	2	77	48	14	25	3	2	2	2	0	179
	10-<11	0	2	5	1	1	48	10	4	10	10	426	49	205	28	6	181	86	1	1073
	11-<12	0	0	0	1	0	2	0	0	1	1	0	13	7	2	4	3	2	0	36
	12-<13	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	2	0	3	0	37	7	8	15	9	0	82
	13-<14	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	1	0	0	5	3	7	1	0	18
	14-<15	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	3	1	5	0	10
	15-<16	0	0	0	1	0	7	0	0	1	0	1	1	3	1	1	70	90	0	176
	>=16	4	0	1	1	0	35	0	1	1	0	13	0	1	2	0	11	583	4	657
Total	16	54	222	280	344	848	477	587	462	236	853	99	317	58	33	322	861	6	6075	

Table 5(b): Cross-tabulation of Number of Respondents by Current Inflation Perception and One Year Ahead Inflation Expectations: Mar-26

One Year Ahead Inflation Rate (per cent)																					
Current Inflation Rate (per cent)		<1	1-<2	2-<3	3-<4	4-<5	5-<6	6-<7	7-<8	8-<9	9-<10	10-<11	11-<12	12-<13	13-<14	14-<15	15-<16	>=16	No idea	Total	
	<1	5	2	2	1	1	3	0	0	0	0	2	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	16	
	1-<2	9	7	43	17	5	3	0	0	1	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	1	0	87	
	2-<3	46	3	55	87	86	100	6	5	2	0	4	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	394	
	3-<4	28	1	3	64	70	169	34	10	9	1	8	0	0	0	0	0	0	1	398	
	4-<5	44	0	6	7	72	97	64	34	17	1	11	1	9	1	2	11	10	0	387	
	5-<6	125	2	7	10	18	289	158	240	143	25	193	4	7	1	0	12	32	0	1266	
	6-<7	41	1	0	3	1	8	67	85	101	39	56	1	11	1	0	0	1	0	416	
	7-<8	59	1	0	1	2	6	2	100	83	54	103	12	17	1	10	5	2	1	459	
	8-<9	39	1	0	0	0	0	5	4	76	47	125	27	65	5	7	11	9	0	421	
	9-<10	20	0	1	0	0	0	1	1	0	37	39	23	34	6	4	10	3	0	179	
	10-<11	90	0	0	2	2	17	2	3	7	2	260	30	183	57	21	244	153	0	1073	
	11-<12	1	0	0	0	0	3	0	0	0	0	0	10	4	4	8	5	1	0	36	
	12-<13	7	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	1	0	0	0	20	9	11	18	15	0	82	
	13-<14	2	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	1	1	0	6	3	2	2	0	18	
	14-<15	0	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	3	1	5	0	10	
	15-<16	16	0	0	0	0	3	0	0	0	0	1	0	0	1	0	0	39	116	0	176
	>=16	69	0	1	0	0	11	0	1	0	0	0	9	0	1	1	0	7	557	0	657
Total	601	18	118	192	257	712	339	483	440	207	811	109	353	92	69	365	907	2	6075		